

Search for the right audience, and build business

Using 'Search' feature of the platform, companies can effectively perform a multi-layered refined search to reach the target audience. It gives easy-to-view audience profiles. So the marketing pitch can be customised for the audience.

"You can use your network to pitch to the connections of the existing client or purely a new entity and find leads. Recently, one of my connections contacted me on LinkedIn when he wanted to get some services job done. So I believe companies are also using LinkedIn to find vendors and service providers," says Jain.

Become a knowledge guru

LinkedIn also offers a good avenue to build knowledge communities around the core services or products of your business. If you are running an advertising agency, you can create a group of advertising professionals and firms, and use the platform to share knowledge and answer queries posted by peers. This is a great way of following and facilitating highly clinical discussions among key opinion leaders in a specific domain.

An interesting case in point is Philips, which established healthcare and lighting communities on LinkedIn to position Philips at the centre of thought-leadership in the healthcare, lighting and well-being industries.

"Over time, this helped the company to build credibility and drive discussion and awareness among key audience for its two main B2B offerings—healthcare and lighting," shares Sapatnekar.

"If you regularly post answers to questions related to your area of expertise, and if your answers are rated best by questioners, it shows up as expertise area on your profile. This leads to winning clients with ease in that domain," adds Singhal.

Have a dashboard view of your ecosystem

The home page of the LinkedIn profile of a user offers all updates related to



his industry, network, employees, customers, competitors, followers, et al on a single page.

For example, with news feeds from across the globe, you can get to know what's happening around the world in the areas of your interest.

"Lately, I have been accessing news and articles posted on the home page of LinkedIn, based on the areas of interest chosen by me. It shows only those articles which are relevant to my industry," observes Jain.

Apart from this, you can know who is viewing your profile and connect with those who could be useful for you or your business in the long run.

LinkedIn offers integration with many applications such as Twitter, Slideshare and YouTube. Once these applications are added to your homepage and profile, they enable you to share and collaborate better, and also control access to the information. (For more information on LinkedIn applications, visit: <http://linkd.in/10EY2>.)

This helps to gain rich insights about business associates and tap opportunities to connect with them better. Singhal explains: "On the LinkedIn 'Home' page of your profile, you can view Tweets made by people in your network, presentations uploaded on slideshare.com and videos uploaded on YouTube. You can also get information about your competitors' travel plans via LinkedIn application TripIt."

"The TripIt application helps me keep my network informed about my trips to places near them and thus we

are able to connect instantly with the people close-by. This way, I was able to tap one important client too," Singhal adds.

You get to know events that may be of interest to you, and also the ones that people in your network, including your competitors, are attending. From the events that your competitors at-

tend, you could extract useful information like the groups they have joined, city they are travelling to and products they are endorsing.

Great resource for niche businesses too

The medium works well for fashion designers, creative artists and so on.

Jain elucidates: "About a month ago, we were looking forward to connect with fashion stylists. We tried multiple networks but were unable to get a good resource bank. We tried LinkedIn as the last resort and were quite surprised to see the number of stylist and designer portfolios on the platform."

In a nutshell

Undeniably, LinkedIn offers value for most critical functions of a company.

Santhosh Ananthapura, manager-corporate and media relations, Acharya Institutes, sums up the key benefits: "You can join professional groups, enhance your knowledge base by participating in discussions, build knowledge communities, connect to relevant people in your industry, perform vendor identification, post job requirements and recruit the right talent, request for referrals, advertise your company, products and services, and also get industry update."

So whether it is sales and marketing, event promotion, HR or networking with people in the business ecosystem, there is a lot that you can do using LinkedIn! ●

Before leaving for Canada recently, she was working as an executive editor at EFM